From Vignette Design to Qualtrics Survey

This guide walks through building a factorial survey in Qualtrics: writing a vignette template, storing the levels of each dimension as Embedded Data, letting a Randomizer draw one level per dimension for every respondent, piping the drawn values into the vignette text, and repeating the set-up for each vignette a respondent rates.

What this guide covers

- Writing the vignette as a question and identifying the dimensions that vary.
- Defining the levels of each dimension in the Survey Flow with Randomizers and Embedded Data.
- Inserting each dimension into the vignette as piped text.
- Keeping pronouns (she/he, her/his) consistent with the randomly drawn gender.
- Previewing the result and repeating the set-up for every vignette.

Step 1. Write the vignette template

Create a block called “Vignette 1” and add one question that holds a complete example vignette, followed by the rating scale (here an 11-point scale from −5 to 5). At this stage the text is static: simply type one realistic version of the vignette so you can see how it reads. Then mark the parts that will vary across respondents. Each of these is a **dimension** (age, gender, education, job tenure, number of children, performance, firm situation and earnings), and the possible values of a dimension are its **levels**.

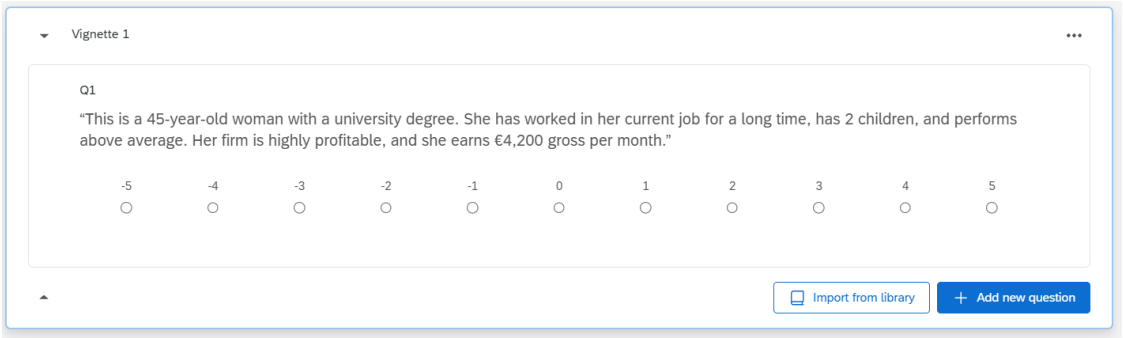


Figure 1. The first vignette written as static text in its own block.

Step 2. Open the Survey Flow

The random draw happens in the Survey Flow, not in the question itself. Open **Survey flow** from the left-hand menu and click **Add a New Element Here**. Two elements from this menu do the work: a **Randomizer**, which picks one of the elements placed inside it, and **Embedded Data**, which stores a value under a field name so it can be reused later in the survey. Every element you add must sit **above** the block that shows the vignette, because Qualtrics runs the flow from top to bottom and a field that has not been set yet appears blank.

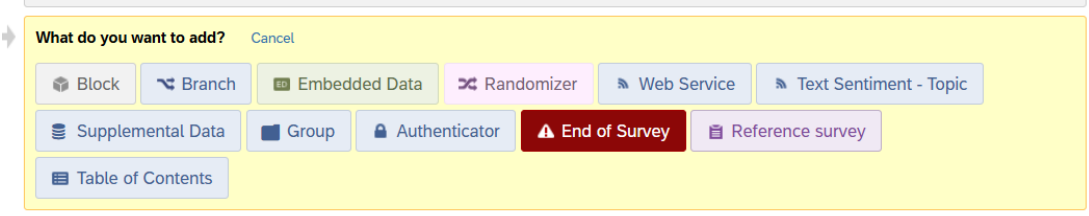


Figure 2. The Survey Flow menu with the Randomizer and Embedded Data elements.

Step 3. Define the levels of each dimension

Add a **Randomizer** and set it to "Randomly present **1** of the following elements", ticking **Evenly present elements** so each level is shown to a similar number of respondents. Inside the Randomizer, add one **Embedded Data** element per level, all using the same field name but a different value: for age, one element sets `age1 = 30`, another `age1 = 40`, and so on. Each respondent then receives exactly one value of `age1`.

Keep each level in its **own** Embedded Data element. If all levels are listed in a single element, as in Figure 3, Qualtrics sets them one after another and every respondent ends up with the last value (here, 60). Repeat this for every dimension, one Randomizer per dimension. Name each field after the dimension plus the vignette number (`age1`, `gender1`, `edu1`, …); the number becomes important in Step 9.

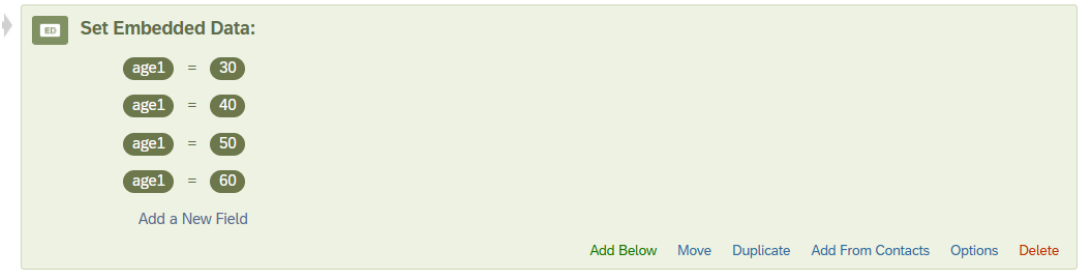


Figure 3. The four levels of the age dimension for vignette 1 (30, 40, 50, 60).

Step 4. Pipe the fields into the vignette

Return to the survey editor and click into the vignette text. Delete the static value you want to replace (for example "45"), keep the cursor there, and choose **Piped Text… → Embedded Data Field**. Type or select the field name (`age1`) and confirm. The field names are not listed automatically, so they must be spelled exactly as in the Survey Flow, including capital letters.

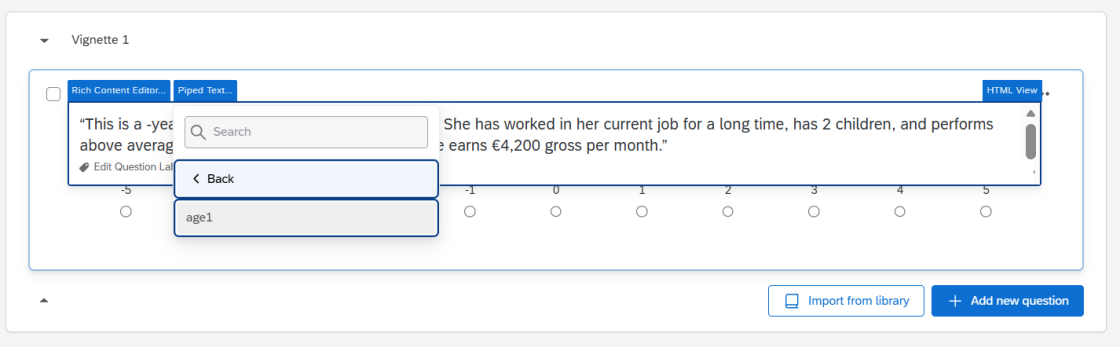


Figure 4. Piped Text → Embedded Data Field, selecting age1.

Step 5. Check the field code

Qualtrics inserts a code of the form `${e://Field/age1}` where the value used to be. When a respondent opens the question, this code is replaced by the level drawn for them. You can also type these codes by hand or copy them between questions, which is faster once you have several dimensions.

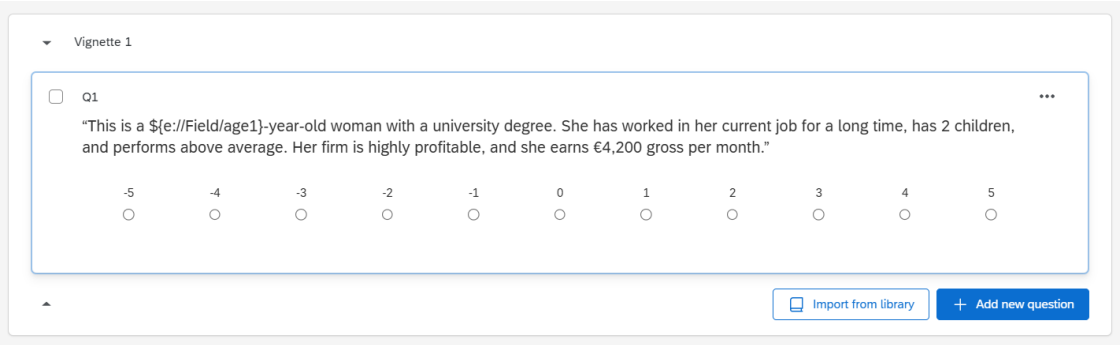


Figure 5. The age value replaced by its piped-text code.

Step 6. Keep pronouns consistent with gender

Gender appears more than once in the vignette: in the noun ("woman"/"man") and in every pronoun that follows. The pronouns must not be drawn at random on their own; they have to follow the gender already drawn. To do this, add two **Branch** elements in the Survey Flow, placed after the gender Randomizer and before the vignette block. The first branch has the condition "If `gender1` Is Equal to woman" and contains an Embedded Data element that sets `Pron1 = She`, `Pos1 = Her`, `pron1 = she` and `pos1 = her`. The second branch does the same for "man" with He/His/he/his.

Separate fields are needed for capitalised and lower-case forms because pronouns appear both at the start of a sentence and in the middle of one. The value in the condition must match the gender level exactly ("woman", not "Woman"), otherwise neither branch runs and the pronouns appear blank.

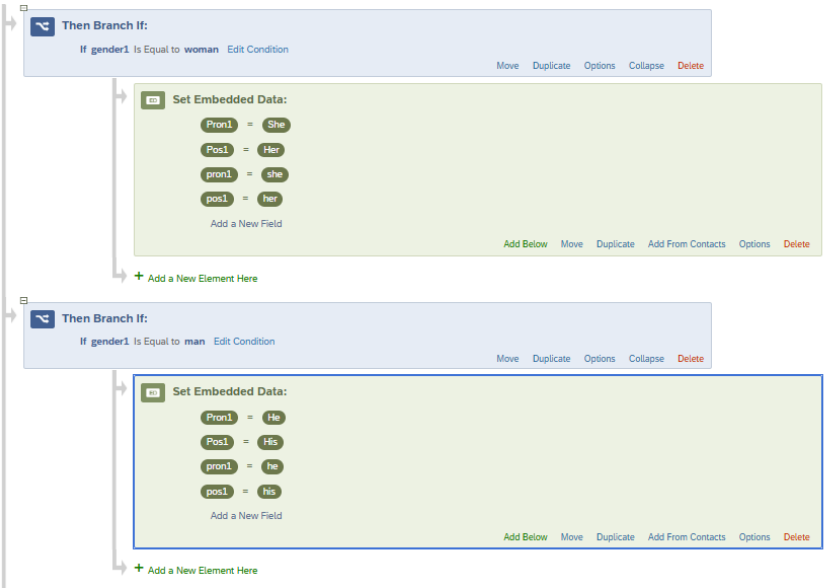


Figure 6. Branches that set the pronouns according to gender1.

Step 7. Complete the vignette template

Replace every remaining static value with its piped field, including the pronoun fields from Step 6. Keep any fixed symbols outside the code: the euro sign, for instance, stays as typed text directly before `${e://Field/earn1}`. The finished template contains only fixed wording and field codes.

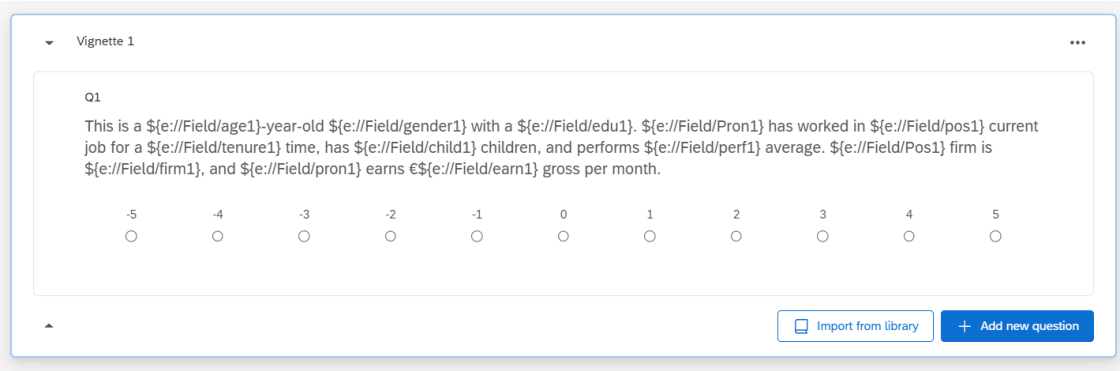


Figure 7. Vignette 1 with every dimension and pronoun piped in.

Step 8. Preview the survey

Click **Preview** and read the rendered vignette carefully: check that no field is blank, that pronouns match the gender, and that numbers and currency display correctly. Preview several times; each new preview is a new respondent, so the combination of levels should change. The levels drawn for each respondent are saved automatically as columns in the dataset, which is what you will use as the independent variables in the analysis.



Figure 8. A rendered vignette as a respondent sees it.

Step 9. Repeat for every vignette

Each vignette a respondent rates needs its own block, its own set of Randomizers and its own pronoun branches. If each respondent rates 15 vignettes, the survey has 15 vignette blocks. Every field must carry the number of its vignette (`age2`, `gender2`, `Pron2`, …). Re-using a name from an earlier vignette would overwrite its value, so the first vignette's levels would be lost from the dataset and both vignettes would show the same text.

The quickest way to build the remaining vignettes is to finish and test vignette 1, then duplicate its block and its Survey Flow elements and rename every field with the new number, both in the flow and in the piped text. In the Survey Flow, each vignette's Randomizers and branches go directly above its own block ("Show Block: Vignette 2").



Figure 9. The fields for vignette 2, named age2 and gender2, placed above the Vignette 2 block.